

ARTISAN CARE GUIDE

How to Clean, Reshape & Repair a Straw Hat

A handwoven straw hat is meant to last decades, not seasons. The weavers of the Rif mountains have cared for these hats for generations — here are the exact steps they use to keep every strand of doum and raffia looking its best.

1. How to clean a straw hat

Straw is a living fibre. It loves a gentle hand and dislikes water, heat and harsh chemicals. For routine dust and salt, this two-step ritual is all you need:

- 1 Dry-brush first.** Using a soft-bristle clothes brush or a clean make-up brush, sweep the brim and crown in the direction of the weave. This lifts dust without snagging the fibres.
- 2 Spot-clean second.** Dampen a white cotton cloth with cool water and a single drop of pH-neutral soap (a baby shampoo works well). Press — never rub — the stain, then dab with a dry cloth to lift the moisture out.

Avoid: machine washing, bleach, alcohol-based wipes, and soaking. All of them dissolve the natural waxes that give the straw its sheen and strength.

2. How to reshape a straw hat with steam

A crushed crown or a wavy brim is almost always recoverable — straw remembers its shape when you give it a little warmth and moisture.

- 1** Bring a kettle to the boil and hold the affected area about 20 cm above the spout for 10–15 seconds. The fibres should feel pliable, never wet.
- 2** With both hands, gently push the crown back into its dome and smooth the brim against a flat surface or a round bowl that matches its curve.
- 3** Let the hat air-dry for at least 12 hours on a hat stand or upside-down on its crown. Do not wear it while it is still warm — the shape sets as it cools.

3. How to repair tears and loose weaves

Small repairs are the difference between a five-year hat and a fifty-year hat. You only need three things: a blunt tapestry needle, matching natural raffia or fine cotton thread, and a clear textile glue.

- **Loose strand:** tuck the strand back into the weave with the needle, then anchor it with a pinhead-sized drop of glue on the underside.
- **Small tear (under 1 cm):** bring the edges together with a row of fine running stitches, knot on the inside, and seal the stitch line with a thin film of glue.
- **Loose ribbon or sweatband:** reattach with a whip stitch in matching cotton thread — never with hot glue, which discolours the straw over time.

Anything larger than a fingernail deserves an artisan's hand. Reach out and we will repair your Rif hat ourselves whenever possible.

4. How to store a straw hat between seasons

- Stuff the crown lightly with acid-free tissue paper to hold its shape.
- Store the hat upside down on its crown, on a wide hat stand, or inside a rigid hat box.
- Keep it cool, dark and dry — never on a sunny shelf, never in a damp cellar, never in a plastic bag.
- Once a month in storage, give it 30 minutes of fresh air to let any humidity escape.

Frequently asked questions

Q · How do I clean a straw hat without damaging it?

Use a soft brush to lift dust, then spot-clean with a barely damp cloth and a drop of mild soap. Never soak a straw hat — water relaxes the weave and can warp the crown and brim.

Q · Can a misshapen straw hat be reshaped at home?

Yes. Hold the brim 20 cm above a kettle for 10–15 seconds so the steam softens the fibres, then gently mould the crown and brim back into shape and let it air-dry on a rounded surface.

Q · How do I repair a small tear or loose weave?

For a loose strand, tuck it back into the weave with a blunt needle and secure it with a drop of clear textile glue. For a small tear, stitch the edges together with matching raffia or cotton thread before sealing with glue.

Q · How should I store a straw hat between seasons?

Stuff the crown with acid-free tissue, store the hat upside down on its crown or on a hat stand, and keep it in a cool, dry, dark place away from direct sun and humidity.

A note from the Rif weavers

Every hat we ship from the Rif is woven by hand from doum palm and raffia harvested in the same valleys our families have worked for generations. Looked after with these simple gestures, your hat will keep its shape, scent and warmth long after the trend cycle has moved on — and that is exactly the point.

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